



Key HR initiatives

- Elevate programme to develop the next generation of leaders
- Contextual masters is a significant initiative to facilitate a better understanding of the customer's business
- Over 36 per cent of the total workforce is made up of women
- LGBTQ is a priority with respect for individuals being a core value
- The process of democratising talent is well-established in the company. Beyond professional qualifications, the real hunt is for employees with the desire and hunger to do well

Two years ago, TCS launched the Elevate programme, with the intention to develop the next generation of leaders. Lakkad counts this as one of the big achievements saying it is also open to people who have been around, for say, 10 years. "We want them to become specialists with a sound understanding of areas such as analytics or security. For those with a longer stint, they can become growth transformation leaders and help customers in a big way," he points out.

The other big one is contextual masters or having a pool of knowledge. "This is useful to ensure there is a greater understanding of the customer's business. It is a process of upskilling our team and good results create a positive energy across the organisation," says Lakkad.

Evidently, there is no limit to how much more

knowledgeable a person can be. According to Purnika Ramesh, who has been in the company for 1.5 years, TCS "does not push you in just one direction". This engineer, for whom TCS was a dream job, is quite kicked about what she is doing. "I can easily go beyond my project and could learn a lot on new technologies for example," she says.

For the more experienced Lalit Lalwani, who has been around for over 11 years, a big learning has been "the value of people and connecting". As Global Head (Digital Customer Experience Management), he is constantly speaking to customers, and not just to offer a service. "I have to solve his problem. After moving to TCS, I understood the value of a strong relationship," he explains.

In a diverse workforce, there are a multitude of issues to be addressed at all times. For Lakkad, a lot of time goes into the area of women's leadership. On the company's rolls are 200,000 women, constituting over 36 per cent of the total employee base. "The strategic priority for this year is to increase diversity at both gender and ethnic levels," he says. Initiatives such as a flexi working policy for young mothers are already in place.

Likewise, LGBTQ is another focus area and Lakkad is clear that at TCS, respect for individuals is a core value. "Our endeavour is to have an equitable and inclusive ecosystem. It is important to create an environment where one is heard," he emphasises.

In a business like this, the most critical recipe for success is really talent. "The people are our primary assets and we do go to the best institutions to recruit them. But the fact is good talent exists everywhere," says Lakkad. He brings up the case of a small city in India or even a village where capability does exist. "We will certainly consider that without any doubt or the smallest sense of bias," he says. Beyond the degree or any professional qualification, the real hunt is for that "desire and hunger to do well". For that to work out well, TCS looks at the larger picture. "The lack of any opportunity should not come in the way. We believe in the ethos of democratising talent."

At TCS, the story is to be in touch with a world where the only constant is change. Lakkad is aware of the complexity involved where the needs of his workforce are effectively aligned with what the customer wants. It is not an easy task to accomplish in the best of times and in a disruptive environment such as the Covid-19 pandemic, it is a tough one to execute. But with a brand like TCS, there is a ready-made platform on which both a robust business and a motivated team can be put in place. **BT**

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